

CHINA'S THREAT
China's latest stealth fighter, the sixth generation J-36, takes to the skies on December 26

DEFENCE | INDIAN AIR FORCE

CHINA'S STEALTH WARNING

The Indian Air Force battles declining numbers in its fighter aircraft and delays in its indigenous projects as China goes beyond 5th-generation jet technology and Pakistan piggybacks on it to build its own strength

By Pradip R. Sagar

IT is a cliché that a problem, if dealt with half-heartedly, increases in magnitude. There has been widespread consensus for long that the Indian Air Force's (IAF) sword arm—its fighter jet force—needs an urgent and substantial boost. Currently, the IAF's combat strength has plummeted to just 31 squadrons (of 18 aircraft each), the lowest since 1965. The IAF has a sanctioned strength of 42 squadrons of fighters, a figure set to address the threat posed by a possible two-front conflict with Pakistan and China. Considering the alarming situation, the Ministry of Defence (MoD) in early December announced the formation of a high-level committee to address the issue. Headed by the defence secretary, the panel will include senior ministry officials, Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) chairman Samir V. Kamat, and senior IAF officers. It will look at the shortage of jets, weapons and other equipment and suggest solutions, including accelerating indigenous production and inviting foreign collaborations. A report is expected in two-three months.

The MoD has reason to worry, for a steep decline in absolute numbers is only one half of the problem—air dominance in the 21st century has moved to fifth generation fighters and beyond, and India has been a laggard in this regard